Jakob von Uexküll — *Theoretische Biologie*, 2nd edition (1928)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Jakob von Uexküll, who revised his theoretical biology for the second edition of 1928 and then watched the English-speaking world go on reading the book he had superseded. The translation of 1926 was based on the first edition, and it was judged so poor that Sebeok blamed it for the late reception of his teaching in the English-speaking world. Few misfortunes are quieter, or more complete, than to be introduced by a version one has already left behind. This edition is dedicated to the author in the form he last chose, translated afresh from his revised German text.

The story

This dossier must begin with an honest correction to the usual shape of a story like this. Jakob von Uexküll's *Theoretische Biologie*, his theoretical biology, is not a book that was never translated. It was translated, and that is precisely where the trouble lies.

The book first appeared in 1920. An English version followed in 1926, translated by D. L. MacKinnon and published by Kegan Paul. But Uexküll then revised the book for a second edition, published by Springer in 1928. Scholarship notes that the English translation "was unfortunately based on the first edition." English

readers therefore received the earlier form of the work, not the form its author later chose.

There is a second part to the trouble. The 1926 translation is widely judged poor. Sebeok called it carried out "wretchedly" under Ogden's auspices, and blamed it for the Umweltlehre's late Anglo-American reception. The Umweltlehre is Uexküll's teaching, central to his biology, whose reception in the English-speaking world was, on that judgement, delayed by the very translation that was supposed to introduce it.

So the gap here is specific, and it should be stated only in that specific form. A revised book exists in German. The revision has not been found in English. The English that does exist is of the superseded edition, and it is widely judged to have served the book badly.

The work and what survives

The second edition of *Theoretische Biologie* was published by Springer in 1928. A fresh English translation of that edition would run to about 378 pages, going by the Suhrkamp reprint.

Other book-length works by the same author are also relevant, and their position must be stated carefully. *Umwelt und Innenwelt der Tiere* (1909) has only an amateur web translation of its introduction found. The pre-1909 physiological works, and *Bausteine zu einer biologischen Weltanschauung* (1913), have no English editions found in the Monoskop bibliography.

His *Streifzüge* (1934) is translated, by Schiller in 1957 and by O'Neil in 2010. It is not a candidate here, and it should not be presented as one.

On copyright, a caution was first recorded and then worked through in full. The 1920 first edition is pre-1930 and public domain in the United States. For the 1928 second edition, the author died in 1944, so a life-plus-70 term expired in 2014 in the European Union, but the United States position for a 1928 foreign work needed a formal check before publication. The 1926 MacKinnon translation also has its own copyright layer: a new translation must be made from the German, not by revising MacKinnon.

That formal check has now been worked in full, covering publication facts, the source-country term, the renewal branch and the URAA branch. The verdict is

that the 1928 German text is public domain in the United States, effective 1 January 2024. The reasoning converges from both branches. First, if United States copyright was secured in 1928 and renewed, the 95-year term from publication expired on 31 December 2023. Second, if protection was lost or never secured through United States formalities — and no United States registration or renewal record for the 1928 Springer edition was surfaced — the URAA restored it on 1 January 1996, because the author died in 1944, so German copyright, life plus 70, ran to 31 December 2014 and subsisted on the restoration date, and a restored work takes the term of a United States work that followed all formalities, the same 95 years from 1928, expiring the same day.

A fresh translation from the 1928 German text may therefore proceed on United States public-domain grounds. Two cautions remain unchanged: the verdict is United States-specific, and MacKinnon's 1926 translation, of the first edition and with its own copyright layer, is not copy-text — a new edition translates from the German. The full analysis and its sources are in `HARDENING-CHECKS-SECOND-PASS.md` §4.

Its English fortunes

Theoretische Biologie (1920) exists in English, translated by D. L. MacKinnon (Kegan Paul, 1926). No English translation of the 1928 revised text found after research.

That is the whole claim, and it is enough. No stronger wording is needed, and none should be used.

What completing it would take

The work required is medium in scale and cleanly scoped: a fresh English translation of the 1928 second edition, about 378 pages in the Suhrkamp reprint, framed exactly as "the revised edition, in English."

No crown is needed. The edition difference is the honest point in its favour. English readers would at last be reading the version Uexküll revised, in a translation made from that German text, rather than the earlier version in a translation that has been judged so harshly.

Sources

- https://monoskop.org/Jakob_von_Uexk%C3%BCll (bibliography of editions/translations)
- https://ojs.utlib.ee/index.php/sss/article/download/SSS.2009.37.1-2.10/10535/15604 (first-edition basis; Sebeok verdict)
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Jakob_von_Uexk%C3%BCll
- https://ngperrin.com/blog/umwelt-und-innenwelt-der-tiere (the 1909 book; amateur intro translation)